

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

CASE STUDY | UTTAR PRADESH

"Unscheduled power cuts spoilt Eid for us"

MOHAMMAD AMIR, *30* | *Tailor,* Dewa Shareef

A tailor in the main market of Dewa, close to Haji Waris Ali Shah's birthplace Dewa Shareef in Barabanki, Mohammad Amir was inundated with orders to stitch clothes before Eid on May 3. Two years of the pandemic lockdown had robbed Eid of all colour, and the residents of Dewa Shareef were determined this time to go all out in celebrating the festival.

Amir worked day and night to finish the 150-odd orders he had received. Except that power cuts played spoilsport. With no power at night, Amir would stitch clothes in the light of his cellphone torch and a candle. Yet, he could not complete all the orders. "There was no lockdown this time, but the unscheduled power cuts stole our Eid." While Amir retained his cool, angry residents in many districts, including Aligarh, Moradabad and Pilibhit, spilled out on to the streets.

The heat wave in April had pushed the demand for electricity to above 22.5 GW, while the state could supply only 19 GW. To compensate for the 3.5 GW shortfall, it had to resort to undeclared power cuts. The state had hoped to supply 18 hours of power to rural areas, and 21.3 hours to Nagar Panchayats and tehsils. However, per an electricity department report, rural areas were getting 9.19 hours, Nagar Panchayats 14.33 hours and tehsil areas 15.07 hours on average. State power minister Arvind Sharma blamed previous governments for UP's power woes: "In the past 50 years, no effort was made to improve the power situation in UP. The public has to bear its brunt." Now that BJP is in its second term, will things change?

–Ashish Misra

The power sector is manned by multiple agencies, each tasked with ensuring the smooth functioning of this critical infrastructure. The power ministry lays down policy, while the Central Electricity Authority (CEA), an arm of the ministry, sets standards, watches trends and set guidelines for the sector. Tariffs in the sector are ratified by the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) for central or multi-state projects, while State Electricity Regulatory Commissions (SERCs) determine tariffs within the states. A touch of oversight could have been handy in times of crisis, but the government was clearly caught on the back foot. Finally, Union home minister Amit Shah convened a multi-ministry meeting on May 2 at his residence. Power minister Singh, railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and coal minister Pralhad Joshi were in attendance. Earlier in the day, the PMO hosted a meeting of the cabinet secretary, home secretary and secretaries of power and coal, with Mrityunjay Mohapatra, chief of the Indian Meteorological Department, making a presentation on the heat wave. These deliberations apart, it is the wider structural issues that the government can no longer ignore, as the power situation is only likely to worsen. What are these?

THE THERMAL CONUNDRUM

Despite the Modi government's thrust on renewable energy sources, India continues to rely heavily on thermal generation to meet its power needs. India's 173 thermal power plants currently have a capacity of 236 GW, or close to 60 per cent of the country's overall capacity. Of these power plants, 86.5 per cent use coal to generate electricity, while the rest depend on lignite, naphtha, diesel and gas. On an annual basis, our thermal plants require 955 million tonnes of coal to fire all their units at full capacity round the clock. In 2021-22, India's power plants used around 530 MT of coal mined within the country, mostly by the state-owned Coal India, and imported an additional 25 MT from countries like Australia, Indonesia and South Africa.

Eighteen of India's thermal plants, with a capacity of 39,000 MW, are situated at the coal pit head, where they are able to source coal efficiently. The other 155 plants, with a capacity of 165,000 MW, are required to maintain a coal stock of 26 per cent;